A CHURCH WEBSITE AND MANAGEMENT PLATFORM

ChurchConnect
Functionality guide

A visitor-friendly church website with a private administration workspace, backed by MongoDB.

DEMO CHURCH	BUILT FOR
Grace Community Church Addis Ababa, Ethiopia	Church visitors, members, and administrators English-first with Ethiopian community options

This guide describes the sample website and current application capabilities. Church name, history, events, and location text are illustrative and should be replaced with approved information.

01 / PUBLIC WEBSITE

A warm first visit

The public side helps people understand the church, find a gathering, and reach a real person. The visual identity combines a custom cross-and-open-book logo, editorial typography, church photography, and responsive page layouts.

Church story and visit information

Home, About, Contact, and Ministries pages introduce the sample church, describe worship, show a general Addis Ababa location, and explain ways to take part.

Events and registration

Visitors can browse upcoming and past events, see time in Addis Ababa time (EAT), and register a group of 1 to 10 people for a future event.

Sermons and announcements

Visitors can browse church messages, open an external media link, search sermons by title or speaker, and read currently published announcements.

Community membership interest

A visitor can ask the welcome team to make contact, choose a preferred language, and optionally share a neighborhood, household name, and introduction.

Prayer and pastoral care

A private form supports prayer, pastoral visits, hospital visits, counseling, bereavement, and family support. People can choose their preferred language and whether they want follow-up.

Contact message

A visitor can send a general question or note through the contact form without exposing the message on the public website.

Calendar and local context

The Events page can display Ethiopian (Amete Mihret) or Gregorian dates. The selected calendar is remembered in the browser. Date and time formatting uses the browser's internationalization support with the Africa/Addis_Ababa time zone; browsers that cannot format the Ethiopic calendar fall back to Gregorian. Ethiopian calendar naming follows Unicode CLDR conventions.

02 / CHURCH TEAM WORKSPACE

Keep the community informed

Administrators sign in to a protected workspace. Member contact details, prayer messages, and general contact submissions are available only through authenticated administration routes.

Content management

Create, edit, and remove events, sermons, announcements, and ministry listings. Announcements have draft/publish and expiry controls; ministries can be hidden without deleting their record.

Welcome team follow-up

Review membership applications by status: pending, contacted, active, or declined. The overview shows the count of applications still waiting for follow-up.

Pastoral care inbox

Read care requests, review them, and see the requested care category, language, and optional contact preference. The inbox is private and supports permanent deletion.

Event attendance

Review registrations by event, see attendee counts and contact details, and mark a registration attended, no-show, cancelled, or restore it to registered.

Dashboard overview

See current counts for site content, active registrations, membership interest, and unreviewed private inbox items. Shortcut cards open the corresponding workspace.

Sample church artwork

The logo is a scalable SVG created for the demo. Sample Unsplash photographs can be replaced with church-owned imagery; image credits and source links are provided in the frontend public images folder.

Ethiopian community options

Public membership and pastoral-care forms offer English, Amharic, Afaan Oromo, and Tigrinya as follow-up language choices. Optional city/neighborhood and household fields support a local welcome process without asking for a street address, date of birth, or other unnecessary identity details.

03 / TECHNOLOGY AND OPERATIONS

How it works

LAYER	TECHNOLOGY	RESPONSIBILITY
Website	React 18, Vite, React Router, responsive CSS	Public pages, accessible forms, event calendar choice, administrator screens
API	Node.js, Express, Zod	REST routes, validation, rate limits, session checks, public/admin separation
Data	MongoDB Atlas with Mongoose	Church content, event registrations, membership applications, and private inbox records
Authentication	bcrypt password hashing; JWT in HTTP-only cookie	Admin-only access to member/contact/care information and content tools

Operational notes

• The API health endpoint reports whether the process can currently reach MongoDB. Public data and forms require both the frontend and API to be running and the backend database connection to succeed.

• MongoDB Atlas must allow the computer or server IP in Network Access, and the backend environment must contain a valid MongoDB connection string, exact frontend origin, and a strong JWT secret. Keep secrets in backend/.env; never commit them or paste them into chat.

• Admin accounts are created by the setup workflow; there is no public administrator sign-up page.

• Input validation, rate limits, CORS restrictions, Helmet headers, small request limits, password hashing, and HTTP-only session cookies are included.

• No donation processing, payment handling, SMS sending, or automatic translation service is implemented. Preferred language is saved for a human follow-up.

Sample deployment checklist

Replace the fictional Grace Community profile and sample records. Confirm the database URI and Atlas IP access, create a private administrator account, use HTTPS in production, review privacy and retention practices for care/member data, and replace or approve the sample imagery. The Unsplash license and photograph credits are recorded in frontend/public/images/IMAGE_CREDITS.md.

Calendar references: MDN Intl.DateTimeFormat; Unicode CLDR calendar names.